Russia and caused a repetition of the clashes between the two powers that had occurred over the previous century.

Russia had historically liked to present itself as a protector of the Christian Armenians and when the Russian army invaded eastern Turkey in 1915 it found itself welcomed by many. The Armenian genocide was mainly carried out by the Turkish army rather than reflecting wider communal violence, but it was a situation in which violence against the 'out-group' was regarded as perfectly sensible in the circumstances, and also fitted with the long history of Ottoman armies taking revenge on civilian populations whom they believed to be in rebellion.

A similar pattern can be seen in Soviet violence against Muslims, as this again was more state-directed violence than inter-communal violence. However, as with the Ottomans, violence had been normalised by the Soviet state and the 1941–3 events can be seen as an extension of the mass murder and starvation inflicted on the wider population in the 1930s.[24] Equally, the Turkic groups who lived in the Crimea, Caucasus and to the north of the Caspian Sea had long been regarded with deep suspicion by the Russian state. As late as the 1600s they had posed a serious threat to a Russian state[25] that was still recovering from the Mongol invasions, and in the 1760s the Crimean Khans had made an alliance with Prussia to attack Russia.[26] In this case, long standing fears about the loyalty of a defined group (similar to Ottoman distrust of the Armenians) combined with a regime that had no limits in terms of the violence it wreaked on its own citizens.

Rwanda shows some similarities and some differences to these two instances. Here the violence was a mixture of communal antagonism and state intervention. The colonial region of Rwanda brought together two different ethnic groups—the Hutus and the Tutsis. Anti-Tutsi sentiment had been built up by the Hutu regime ever since Rwanda became independent.[27] Under Belgian colonial rule (after the region was transferred from German rule at the end of World War I), the minority Tutsi population (some 14 per cent of the total population) had had a privileged role in helping to administer the colony. After independence, some politicians from the Hutu majority claimed that the Tutsis were unreliable and still owed their primary loyalty to a foreign power. Both the Germans and Belgians had played on existing ethnic divisions to ease their own control over the territory, and to